

SHIKHAR SHUKLA

Behavioral & UX Research | Qualitative, Ethnographic & Heuristic Methods

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Independent researcher with a software engineering background — six months of embedded workplace ethnography, plus five self-initiated studies spanning behavioral research and UX/heuristic audits of live products (Zipcar, Wise, Decathlon). Skilled at identifying gaps between stated intent and observed behavior, running structured evaluations against established frameworks, and translating findings into prioritized, testable interventions for product and research teams.

Methods: ethnographic observation · semi-structured interviewing · heuristic evaluation (Nielsen's 10 heuristics) · cognitive/FTUE walkthroughs · cross-group triangulation · hypothesis-driven behavioral modeling · stakeholder-ready reporting & executive briefs

SELECTED RESEARCH

Surface Compliance, Silent Resistance

Real-World Workplace Ethnography · Independent Behavioral Research · Jan–Aug 2026 · Two-Part Study

Research question: When management introduces control-based policies in response to a perceived productivity problem, what behavioral patterns emerge in the affected team, and how does that pattern evolve as management escalates from control toward personnel removal?

- 6-month embedded ethnographic observation of a 7-person software team, conducted as an active insider with real-time access to policy rollout and management interactions; cross-validated against a natural internal control group and a cross-team bridge role.
- Developed the **Control–Trust–Output Loop**, a behavioral model showing how management's structural control policies were read as distrust signals — decreasing discretionary effort and output, and prompting further controls that reproduced the original problem.
- Synthesized field evidence into 3 testable hypotheses and 3 proposed interventions (a requirements-alignment discovery sprint, embedding a developer in client deadline discussions, and replacing presence tracking with outcome metrics).
- **Part 2 — The Exit Arc (Jul–Aug 2026):** tracked the loop into a terminal phase as management's controls escalated from policy into personnel-level consequences, including the observer's own exit — captured as reflexive data rather than left out of the analysis.
- Identified a structural mirror: management's own flight from direct client accountability matched the same avoidance behavior it had been punishing in employees.
- Extended the Control–Trust–Output Loop into an 11-stage terminal model and proposed 3 crisis-stage interventions to replace scapegoating with root-cause discovery.

Full case studies — Part 1 (18-page): [Read on Google Docs](#) · Part 2 – The Exit Arc: [Read on Google Docs](#)

The Six-Week Silence

Simulated Qualitative Research Exercise (dummy data) · 2026

- Conducted a structured, interview-based investigation into a 5-person team, reconstructing the chain of individually reasonable assumptions that led four members to reorganize their behavior around an unverified interpretation over six weeks.
- Used a group debrief to reframe the issue from individual blame to a systemic feedback-loop failure, and proposed a one-week “assumption tripwire” intervention triggering a direct check-in instead of a default explanation.

Case study: [Read on Google Docs](#) · Writing archive: [shikharshukla26.substack.com](#)

UX / PRODUCT RESEARCH — INDEPENDENT, UNAFFILIATED AUDITS

Zipcar — First-Time Experience (FTUE) Audit · *N=1 exploratory walkthrough & heuristic evaluation, self-initiated · 2026*

- Conducted a self-initiated FTUE audit of zipcar.com's homepage and booking flow; surfaced 2 high-priority findings, headlined by service-category ambiguity that persists for several seconds after the page loads.
- The second finding — no visible confirmation after editing search fields — left it unclear whether an edit had registered; reframed both as untested hypotheses and designed two 5-user validation tests (task, research question, success criteria) to run before any engineering work begins.

[Brief](#) · [Full version](#)

Decathlon.in — Heuristic Evaluation of the Purchase Journey · *8 findings, Nielsen's 10 heuristics · Sep 2026*

- Conducted a solo heuristic evaluation of Decathlon.in's purchase journey (search → payment) against Nielsen's 10 heuristics; surfaced 8 findings, headlined by cycles being non-returnable with no disclosure before purchase — flagged as a legal/trust risk.
- Mapped every finding to its implementation effort (copy change vs. engineering) and prioritized 3 as high-impact and fixable without a redesign.

[Brief](#) · [Full version](#)

Wise India — Onboarding & Signup Heuristic Evaluation · *16-screenshot walkthrough, 6 decision points · Sep 2026*

- Conducted a cognitive walkthrough of Wise.com's transfer and signup flow for a first-time, India-based visitor against Nielsen's 10 heuristics; surfaced 3 priority findings, headlined by a silent signup failure when selecting “Personal” + “India”.
- Left eligibility unresolved at the highest-intent moment in the funnel; proposed 3 fixes and a moderated 5–8 user validation study as the next step.

[Brief](#) · [Full version](#)

BEHAVIORAL & PRODUCT PSYCHOLOGY WRITING

First-person research and writing on how digital products shape attention and decision-making — persuasive design, dark patterns, and metacognitive hijacking.

- "YouTube Is Not Your Problem. Tomorrow Is." — first-person analysis of digital escape and thought suppression.
- "How YouTube Controls Your Thinking Before You Notice" — breakdown of 7 UX mechanisms engineered to prevent users from stopping.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

DevLoops Technologies Pvt Ltd — Software Development Engineer I Jan 2026 – Aug 2026

- Sole full-stack developer on production platforms for international clients (UK, Canada, Netherlands, USA) and Indian healthcare — owned architecture, backend, frontend, and cloud infrastructure end-to-end.
- Designed multi-role access systems (5–6 roles) governing how information and permissions flow through an organization — including a 900+ field Canadian real-estate appraisal workflow and a UK VAT reconciliation platform.
- Built and shipped a live healthcare platform (multi-role access, payments, appointment booking, notifications) used by active clinics — direct exposure to how real users behave inside a structured, role-based workflow.

DevLoops Technologies Pvt Ltd — Intern Engineer → Software Development Training Mar 2025 – Dec 2025

- Built the company's corporate website with a custom no-code admin panel; delivered a trilingual (EN/NL/Flemish) CMS, data migration (1,000+ contacts), and analytics dashboard for a Netherlands-based client, plus a logistics website for a US-based trucking company.

EDUCATION

B.Tech, Mechatronics — ITM Vocational University · CGPA 7.85 2020 – 2023

Diploma, Mechatronics — ITM Vocational University · CGPA 7.00 2017 – 2020

CERTIFICATIONS

Namaste React (2025) · Complete JavaScript Course (Udemy, 2024) · Namaste JavaScript (2024) — NamasteDev.com